

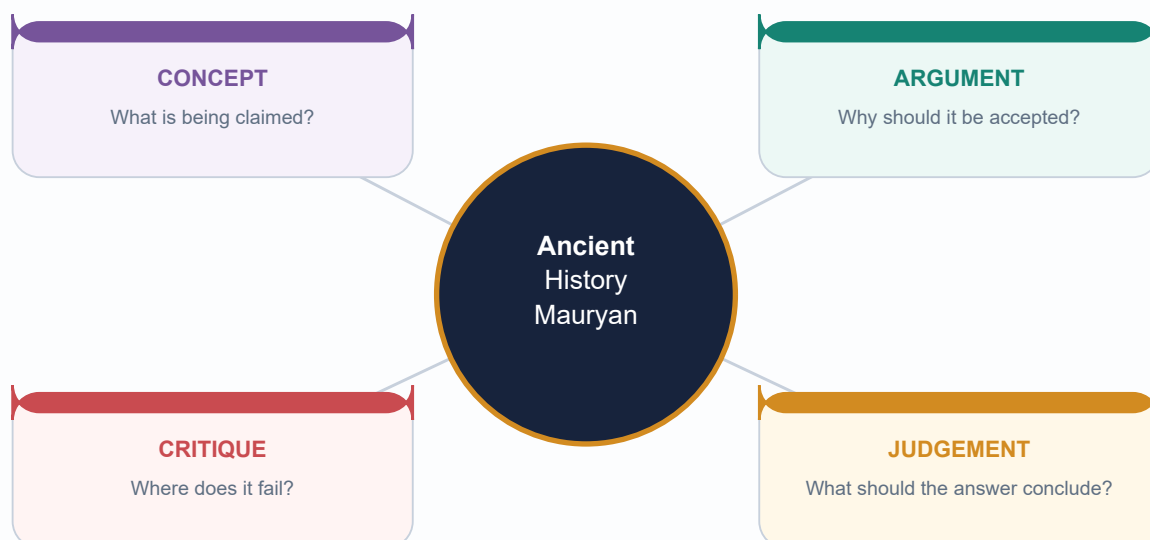
UPSC SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Ancient History 14 | The Mauryan Empire | Solved Practice Workbook

Ancient Indian History | Prelims GS-I + GS-II

Strict original-MCQ key rotation: A -> B -> C -> D

Generated 2026-08-13 | approved=false pending explicit approval



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Workbook scope and evidence discipline

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Seven verified/routed PYQs, 48 hard MCQs, 12 remedials and three each of solved 10-, 15- and 20-mark original Mains questions. Objective keys rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Prelims	Printed local official papers	Exact question demand	Unavailable local keys marked inferred
Mains	Verified 2020 GS-I rock-cut question + originals	Directive and evidence practice	No official model answer is claimed
Rotation	60 original objective questions	Strict anti-bias sequence	PYQ answer letters retain actual/inferred keys
Answer standard	Named inscription/site/text/official/artefact	Evidence-led analysis	Every claim includes a limitation where relevant

STATIC THEORY

- Attempt questions before reading solutions.
- For every error, identify whether it arose from chronology, source genre, map, terminology or overstatement.
- Use the Why this earns marks notes as a self-review rubric.

MEMORY HOOK

Attempt -> justify -> check source -> record trap.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Strict ABCD rotation is applied to original MCQs.
2. approved=false until explicit approval.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Memorise option letters only.

CORRECT: Reconstruct the evidence and elimination logic.

WRONG: Use a PYQ inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Keep verification status visible.

HIGH

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2019 Q8: Ranyo Ashoka portrait

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

A verified/routed UPSC demand solved with exact evidence status. Where the official key is unavailable locally, the answer is explicitly labelled inferred.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Kanaganahalli	Raya/Ranyo Asoko label with royal reliefs	Correct identification	Reliefs are 2nd-3rd century CE memories, not lifetime portraits
Sanchi	Later reliefs interpreted as Ashoka scenes	Important memory of Ashoka	The named inscription in this PYQ is not Sanchi
Shahbazgarhi	Kharoshthi Major Rock Edicts	Ashokan epigraphy	Not a portrait-relief site
Sohgaura	Debated early-historic famine/storehouse plaque	Administrative-history evidence	Not a portrait-relief inscription

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka) mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka?

- A. Kanganahalli
- B. Sanchi
- C. Shahbazgarhi
- D. Sohgaura

- ANSWER: A - Kanganahalli

- VERIFICATION: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official question paper controls wording; the official key is not held in the repository.

- The Kanaganahalli stupa excavations produced limestone reliefs labelled 'Raya Asoko' and showing a king with a queen and attendants.

- The sculptures were made centuries after Ashoka; they reveal his early iconic memory in Buddhist art rather than his actual appearance.

- Elimination works by separating an art-memory site from rock-edict and administrative-inscription sites.

- Why this earns marks: It gives the key, identifies the labelled artefact, distinguishes representation from eyewitness portraiture, and eliminates each distractor by evidence class.

MEMORY HOOK

Question -> evidence -> elimination -> source caveat.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A - Kanganahalli
2. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED
LOCALLY. The local official question paper controls wording; the official key is not held in the repository.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Treat an inferred key as official.**CORRECT:** Keep the inference label visible.**WRONG:** Give the key without source logic.**CORRECT:** State the named edict, site, text or artefact that controls elimination.**MAINS ANGLE***Demand fidelity first; then add the precise evidence and limitation.***STUDY LINK**

Local official paper and Topic 14 source matrix.

HIGH**Verified Prelims PYQ - 2020 Q30: sectarian concord inscription**Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

A verified/routed UPSC demand solved with exact evidence status. Where the official key is unavailable locally, the answer is explicitly labelled inferred.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Named source	Major Rock Edict XII	Restraint in praising one's sect and condemning others	Translation wording varies
Positive demand	Growth in essentials and listening to other sects	Concord exceeds passive toleration	Royal exhortation is not proof of harmony
Ashoka's position	Honours all sects while personally Buddhist	Separates public policy from personal faith	Paternal royal authority remains
Distractors	Prashasti/court traditions of later rulers	Different genres and periods	Religious patronage alone does not identify the quotation

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect very severely'?

- A. Ashoka
- B. Samudragupta
- C. Harshavardhana
- D. Krishnadeva Raya
- ANSWER: A - Ashoka

- VERIFICATION: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The wording is from the local 2020 official paper; repository routing records no local official key.

- The quotation condenses Ashoka's Major Rock Edict XII.

- The decisive phrase is not generic tolerance but the injury caused to one's own sect by excessive self-praise and denunciation of others.

- A high-quality explanation adds that Ashoka sought dialogue and growth in the essentials of all sects, not a modern secular state.

- Why this earns marks: It anchors the answer to a named edict and explains the ethical-political content instead of relying on ruler recognition alone.

MEMORY HOOK

Question -> evidence -> elimination -> source caveat.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A - Ashoka
2. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The wording is from the local 2020 official paper; repository routing records no local official key.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Treat an inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Keep the inference label visible.

WRONG: Give the key without source logic.

CORRECT: State the named edict, site, text or artefact that controls elimination.

MAINS ANGLE

Demand fidelity first; then add the precise evidence and limitation.

STUDY LINK

Local official paper and Topic 14 source matrix.

HIGH**Verified Prelims PYQ - 2022 Q60: Arthashastra and slavery**

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

A verified/routed UPSC demand solved with exact evidence status. Where the official key is unavailable locally, the answer is explicitly labelled inferred.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Statement 1	Judicial punishment wording	Not accepted in the keyed text interpretation	Translations and slavery categories require care
Statement 2	Freedom of the mother after bearing master's son	Correct Arthashastra provision	Normative law, not social census
Statement 3	Status of the son	Correct legal provision	Does not establish frequency or empire-wide implementation
Historical use	Arthashastra slavery rules	Evidence for legal-political thought	Not transparent Mauryan practice

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, consider: (1) a person could be a slave as a result of judicial punishment; (2) if a female slave bore her master a son, she was legally free; (3) such a son fathered by the master had the legal status of the master's son. Which are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only

- B. 2 and 3 only

- C. 1 and 3 only

- D. 1, 2 and 3

- ANSWER: B - 2 and 3 only

- VERIFICATION: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held. The key follows the text-based legal distinction.

- Statements 2 and 3 form a connected legal rule on manumission and filial status.

- The question asks 'according to the Arthashastra'; it does not ask what Ashoka's administration practised.

- The package therefore solves the objective demand while preserving the composition/redaction and prescription caveat.

- Why this earns marks: It demonstrates demand fidelity: text-specific answer first, then source criticism without allowing the caveat to obscure the key.

MEMORY HOOK

Question -> evidence -> elimination -> source caveat.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. B - 2 and 3 only

2. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held. The key follows the text-based legal distinction.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Treat an inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Keep the inference label visible.

WRONG: Give the key without source logic.

CORRECT: State the named edict, site, text or artefact that controls elimination.

MAINS ANGLE

Demand fidelity first; then add the precise evidence and limitation.

STUDY LINK

Local official paper and Topic 14 source matrix.

HIGH

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2022 Q91: Major Rock Edict sites

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

A verified/routed UPSC demand solved with exact evidence status. Where the official key is unavailable locally, the answer is explicitly labelled inferred.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Dhauli	Odisha	Correct; Separate Kalinga Edicts replace part of standard set	Modern district references can change
Erragudi	Andhra Pradesh	Correct; Major and minor rock-edict context	Spelling Yerragudi/Erragudi varies
Jaugada	Odisha, not Madhya Pradesh	Incorrect pair	Kalinga regional context
Kalsi	Uttarakhand, not Karnataka	Incorrect pair	North Indian Himalayan-foothill route

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Consider the pairs: Dhauli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-Karnataka. How many are correctly matched?

- A. Only one pair
- B. Only two pairs
- C. Only three pairs
- D. All four pairs

- ANSWER: B - Only two pairs

- VERIFICATION: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held.

- Only Dhauli-Odisha and Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh are correct.

- A map-first method prevents phonetic or vague-regional guessing.

- Dhauli and Jaugada should be mentally paired as Kalinga sites; Kalsi belongs to Uttarakhand.

- Why this earns marks: It supplies exact state corrections and links geography to inscription category, creating durable elimination memory.

MEMORY HOOK

Question -> evidence -> elimination -> source caveat.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. B - Only two pairs
2. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Treat an inferred key as official.**CORRECT:** Keep the inference label visible.**WRONG:** Give the key without source logic.**CORRECT:** State the named edict, site, text or artefact that controls elimination.**MAINS ANGLE***Demand fidelity first; then add the precise evidence and limitation.***STUDY LINK**

Local official paper and Topic 14 source matrix.

HIGH**Verified Prelims PYQ - 2025 Q19: Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta**Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

A verified/routed UPSC demand solved with exact evidence status. Where the official key is unavailable locally, the answer is explicitly labelled inferred.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Pradeshika	Rock Edict III tour context	District-level field officer	Exact rank/function not identical to modern district magistrate
Rajuka	Land-measurement hypothesis; justice/welfare/dhamma	High field responsibility	Etymology is not a complete job description
Yukta	Directed duties and tours	Subordinate/executive accounting-administrative role	Context changes
Collective context	Five-year tours for dhamma and other purposes	District-level administration	No single modern hierarchy should be forced

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important officers at which level?

- A. Village-level administration
- B. District-level administration
- C. Provincial administration
- D. Central administration

- ANSWER: B - District-level administration

- VERIFICATION: OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Local UPSC 2025 Series-A key marks Q19 as B.

- The official answer is district-level administration.

- Rock Edict III groups the three for quinquennial tours, while other inscriptions expand rajuka duties.

- The examination fact should be retained without pretending that the three offices were identical.

- Why this earns marks: It uses the official local key, names the edict context, and protects against over-modernising ancient titles.

MEMORY HOOK

Question -> evidence -> elimination -> source caveat.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. B - District-level administration
2. OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Local UPSC 2025 Series-A key marks Q19 as B.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Treat an inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Keep the inference label visible.

WRONG: Give the key without source logic.

CORRECT: State the named edict, site, text or artefact that controls elimination.

MAINS ANGLE

Demand fidelity first; then add the precise evidence and limitation.

STUDY LINK

Local official paper and Topic 14 source matrix.

HIGH**Verified adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2023 Q42: stupa origin and function**

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

A verified/routed UPSC demand solved with exact evidence status. Where the official key is unavailable locally, the answer is explicitly labelled inferred.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Statement 1	Funerary mound tradition predates/exceeds Buddhism	Incorrect	Buddhism transformed and popularised the form
Statement 2	Relic enshrinement	Correct for many Buddhist stupas	Not every stupa necessarily held relics
Statement 3	Votive and commemorative roles	Correct	Functions changed by site and period
Mauryan link	Sanchi brick core; Nigali Sagar enlargement	Ashoka's major patronage phase	Later visible additions must be dated separately

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. All three
- D. None

- ANSWER: B - Only two

- VERIFICATION: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included because Ashokan stupa patronage is a Topic 14 subtheme.

- Statements 2 and 3 are correct; the stupa form was not exclusively Buddhist in origin.

- Ashoka's significance lies in patronage, enlargement, commemoration and popularisation, not invention of the mound.

- Sanchi's Mauryan brick core and later gateways provide the crucial chronology trap.

- Why this earns marks: It answers the objective demand and ties the result to a precise Mauryan architectural chronology.

MEMORY HOOK

Question -> evidence -> elimination -> source caveat.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. B - Only two
2. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included because Ashokan stupa patronage is a Topic 14 subtheme.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Treat an inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Keep the inference label visible.

WRONG: Give the key without source logic.

CORRECT: State the named edict, site, text or artefact that controls elimination.

MAINS ANGLE

Demand fidelity first; then add the precise evidence and limitation.

STUDY LINK

Local official paper and Topic 14 source matrix.

HIGH

Verified adjacent Mains PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q1: rock-cut architecture

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

A verified/routed UPSC demand solved with exact evidence status. Where the official key is unavailable locally, the answer is explicitly labelled inferred.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Mauryan beginning	Barabar caves; Ashokan Ajivika dedications	Imperial patronage, ascetic space and rock technology	Lomash Rishi itself has no Ashokan dedication
Formal idea	Hut/wooden forms translated into rock	Tradition reworked through durable medium	Chronology and patronage vary
Later expansion	Buddhist chaitya-vihara complexes such as Bhaja/Ajanta	Ritual movement, congregational worship and monastic residence	Later evidence should not be backdated
Plural traditions	Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical caves	Philosophy and patronage shaped form and iconography	Material, labour and politics also matter

STATIC THEORY

- QUESTION: Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss with reference to rock-cut architecture. (10 marks, 150 words)

- ANSWER: Model answer

- VERIFICATION: VERIFIED QUESTION from the local official 2020 GS-I paper. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Barabar and Mauryan beginnings.

- THESIS: Rock-cut architecture materialised Indian traditions of renunciation, sacred presence, congregation and patronage, while craftsmen transformed earlier wooden forms into enduring stone.

- MODEL: The Mauryan Barabar caves provide the earliest surviving imperial stage: Ashoka's inscriptions dedicate highly polished caves to Ajivikas, linking royal patronage with ascetic withdrawal. The Lomash Rishi facade imitates a timber-and-thatch entrance, showing translation rather than mere copying. Later Buddhist chaityas organised worship around a stupa and circumambulation, while viharas institutionalised monastic residence; Jain and Brahmanical caves adapted the medium to their own sacred narratives and icons. Yet philosophy alone did not cut rock: court or mercantile patronage, quarrying skill, labour and route-linked monastic economies made these monuments possible. Thus ideas supplied purpose and symbolism, while technology and institutions shaped the realised form.

- VERDICT: Rock-cut architecture is evidence of interaction among doctrine, ritual, patronage, material technology and landscape.

- Why this earns marks: It directly discusses the role of philosophy/tradition, uses Barabar and later comparators, adds material causation, and avoids calling every early cave Buddhist.

MEMORY HOOK

Question -> evidence -> elimination -> source caveat.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Model answer
2. VERIFIED QUESTION from the local official 2020 GS-I paper. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Barabar and Mauryan beginnings.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Treat an inferred key as official.

CORRECT: Keep the inference label visible.

WRONG: Give the key without source logic.

CORRECT: State the named edict, site, text or artefact that controls elimination.

MAINS ANGLE

Demand fidelity first; then add the precise evidence and limitation.

STUDY LINK

Local official paper and Topic 14 source matrix.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 01 - Source method

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which source is securely contemporary with Ashoka and most directly reveals his public political-ethical voice?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Ashokan edicts	Correct	They reveal intention and self-presentation more securely than implementation.
B	The final redacted Arthashastra	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Ashokavadana legends	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Megasthenes as quoted by Strabo alone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Ashokan edicts
- EXPLANATION: The edicts are royal proclamations dated to Ashoka's reign.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major/minor rock and pillar inscriptions
- QUALIFICATION: They reveal intention and self-presentation more securely than implementation.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Source method.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 02 - Chronology

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which sequence is chronologically correct?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Bindusara -> Chandragupta -> Ashoka	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Chandragupta -> Bindusara -> Ashoka	Correct	Exact accession years vary.
C	Ashoka -> Chandragupta -> Bindusara	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Chandragupta -> Ashoka -> Bindusara	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Chandragupta -> Bindusara -> Ashoka
- EXPLANATION: The first three major Mauryas were Chandragupta, Bindusara and Ashoka.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Puranic/classical/traditional dynastic reconstruction
- QUALIFICATION: Exact accession years vary.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Chronology.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 03 - Arthashastra

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What is the safest use of the Arthashastra in a Mauryan answer?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	As the official Mauryan civil-service manual	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	As an Ashokan edict collection	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	As a theoretical statecraft text whose Mauryan application needs corroboration	Correct	Earlier ideas within the text may predate its final composition.
D	As Megasthenes' lost eyewitness diary	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - As a theoretical statecraft text whose Mauryan application needs corroboration
- EXPLANATION: Current scholarship treats the extant text as theoretical and substantially post-Mauryan/redacted.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Upinder Singh Chapter 7; Olivelle/McClish debate
- QUALIFICATION: Earlier ideas within the text may predate its final composition.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Arthashastra.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 04 - Megasthenes

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Why is Megasthenes described as evidence passing through a 'double filter'?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	He wrote first in Brahmi and then translated himself into Greek	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Two Mauryan kings censored every passage	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	The Indica survives in two complete manuscripts	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	His observations were interpreted by him and then selected by later Graeco-Roman writers	Correct	Some observations are useful when independently corroborated.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - His observations were interpreted by him and then selected by later Graeco-Roman writers
- EXPLANATION: The original Indica is lost; fragments survive through later authors.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny
- QUALIFICATION: Some observations are useful when independently corroborated.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Megasthenes.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 05 - Seleucus treaty

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which element belongs to the Chandragupta-Seleucus treaty tradition?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Transfer of 500 elephants to Seleucus	Correct	Exact date, marriage clause and territorial control remain debated.
B	Ashoka's surrender of Kalinga	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Bindusara's gift of the Sarnath capital	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Seleucus becoming governor of Taxila	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Transfer of 500 elephants to Seleucus
- EXPLANATION: Classical sources associate the settlement with territorial transfer and 500 elephants.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Graeco-Roman treaty tradition
- QUALIFICATION: Exact date, marriage clause and territorial control remain debated.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Seleucus treaty.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 06 - Bindusara

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about Bindusara is most defensible?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	He issued the complete pillar-edict series	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	He maintained Hellenistic diplomatic contacts, but the evidence for his conquests is thin	Correct	Most evidence is later and fragmentary.
C	He founded the dynasty after Kalinga	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	His Deccan conquest is documented by a contemporary victory inscription	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - He maintained Hellenistic diplomatic contacts, but the evidence for his conquests is thin
- EXPLANATION: Envoy traditions are firmer than detailed conquest narratives.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Deimachus/Dionysius notices; late Taranatha account
- QUALIFICATION: Most evidence is later and fragmentary.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Bindusara.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 07 - Imperial extent

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What does an Ashokan edict find-spot most securely establish?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Uniform direct administration of the entire surrounding region	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	A permanent Mauryan garrison of known size	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Imperial contact and an attempt at communication at or near that location	Correct	Effective control must be tested with regional archaeology and context.
D	Absence of all local political institutions	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Imperial contact and an attempt at communication at or near that location
- EXPLANATION: Find-spots are evidence of message placement and authority claims.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Distribution of major/minor edicts
- QUALIFICATION: Effective control must be tested with regional archaeology and context.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Imperial extent.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 08 - Provinces

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which pairing is correctly associated with a reconstructed Mauryan provincial centre?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Tosali - north-western province	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Taxila - Kalinga province	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Ujjayini - eastern Bengal province	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Suvarnagiri - southern province	Correct	The four-province scheme is reconstructed, not a complete official list.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Suvarnagiri - southern province
- EXPLANATION: Suvarnagiri is associated with the southern administrative network.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Ashokan inscriptional geography
- QUALIFICATION: The four-province scheme is reconstructed, not a complete official list.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Provinces.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 09 - Officers

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

The 2025 official Set-A key places Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta primarily at which level?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	District level	Correct	Their precise relative ranks and functions remain debated.
B	Village level	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Central court only	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Foreign embassy level	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - District level
- EXPLANATION: The locally held official key marks district-level administration.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: UPSC 2025 Q19; Rock Edict III
- QUALIFICATION: Their precise relative ranks and functions remain debated.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Officers.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 10 - Mahamattas

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which officer category was specially created by Ashoka in his thirteenth consecrated year?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Samahartas	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Dhamma-mahamattas	Correct	They were ethical-welfare officials, not merely Buddhist missionaries.
C	Sannidhata	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Senapatis	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Dhamma-mahamattas
- EXPLANATION: Major Rock Edict V records the new dhamma cadre.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict V
- QUALIFICATION: They were ethical-welfare officials, not merely Buddhist missionaries.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Mahamattas.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 11 - Rajuka

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which description best fits the rajuka under Ashoka?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	A hereditary village priest only	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	A Greek ambassador to Pataliputra	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	A high field officer with land-measurement associations and later judicial, welfare and dhamma duties	Correct	The derivation from rajju is suggestive, not conclusive.
D	The keeper of the royal treasury in the Arthashastra	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - A high field officer with land-measurement associations and later judicial, welfare and dhamma duties
- EXPLANATION: The edicts expand rajuka responsibilities beyond a possible surveying origin.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rock Edict III; Pillar Edict IV
- QUALIFICATION: The derivation from rajju is suggestive, not conclusive.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Rajuka.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 12 - Reporting

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What is the central administrative claim of Rock Edict VI?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	All land was owned by the king	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	The sangha elected provincial governors	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Kalinga was restored to independence	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Reporters should convey public affairs to the king at any time and place	Correct	It is a command/ideal, not proof of instantaneous empire-wide compliance.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Reporters should convey public affairs to the king at any time and place
- EXPLANATION: The edict presents strenuous royal accessibility and rapid reporting.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rock Edict VI
- QUALIFICATION: It is a command/ideal, not proof of instantaneous empire-wide compliance.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Reporting.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 13 - Justice

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which evidence proves Ashoka did not abolish capital punishment?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Pillar Edict IV's three-day respite for condemned prisoners	Correct	The edict simultaneously urges fairness and mercy.
B	Rock Edict XII on sectarian concord	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	The Bhabru recommendation of Buddhist texts	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	The Sarnath lion capital	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Pillar Edict IV's three-day respite for condemned prisoners
- EXPLANATION: A respite presupposes the continued death sentence.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Pillar Edict IV
- QUALIFICATION: The edict simultaneously urges fairness and mercy.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Justice.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 14 - Military

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which conclusion about Ashoka's post-Kalinga military policy is safest?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	He dissolved every military unit immediately	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	He preferred dhamma-vijaya but retained coercive power and did not announce army disbandment	Correct	The frequency of later coercive operations is unknown.
C	He returned Kalinga and ended taxation	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	He renounced all judicial punishment	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - He preferred dhamma-vijaya but retained coercive power and did not announce army disbandment
- EXPLANATION: Rock Edict XIII combines anti-war remorse with a warning to forest peoples.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict XIII
- QUALIFICATION: The frequency of later coercive operations is unknown.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Military.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 15 - Revenue

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about Mauryan land revenue is most accurate?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	One-fourth was uniformly collected everywhere	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	No agrarian tax existed after Kalinga	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Rates and actual collection varied across regions and sources	Correct	A concession at one village is not an empire-wide schedule.
D	Every plot was legally owned by Ashoka	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Rates and actual collection varied across regions and sources
- EXPLANATION: Rummindei, classical notices and normative one-sixth claims differ.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rummindei pillar; Megasthenes fragments; textual norms
- QUALIFICATION: A concession at one village is not an empire-wide schedule.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Revenue.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 16 - Rummindei

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What fiscal measure is recorded at Lumbini in the Rummindei inscription?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Creation of six army committees	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Abolition of all taxes in Kalinga	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Appointment of Seleucus as governor	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Exemption from bali and reduction of bhaga to one-eighth	Correct	The prior rate and precise meaning of bali need caution.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Exemption from bali and reduction of bhaga to one-eighth
- EXPLANATION: The inscription links pilgrimage, commemoration and a local tax concession.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rummindei pillar inscription
- QUALIFICATION: The prior rate and precise meaning of bali need caution.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Rummindei.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 17 - Irrigation

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which evidence connects Chandragupta's and Ashoka's administrations with the Sudarshana reservoir?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription	Correct	It is retrospective evidence written centuries later.
B	Major Rock Edict XII	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	The Kanaganahalli portrait label	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Megasthenes' seven social groups	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription
- EXPLANATION: The later inscription credits Pushyagupta and Tushaspha in the reservoir's history.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman
- QUALIFICATION: It is retrospective evidence written centuries later.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Irrigation.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 18 - Economy debate

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which position best fits the evidence on Mauryan economic control?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	A proven total command economy	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Selective and regionally varied state intervention alongside local and private activity	Correct	Arthashastra monopolies are prescriptions, not an audited economy.
C	A state with no taxation or regulation	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	An economy controlled exclusively by Buddhist monasteries	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Selective and regionally varied state intervention alongside local and private activity
- EXPLANATION: Inscriptions show partial interventions; archaeology shows multiple actors.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rummindei, Sudarshana, towns, coins and crafts
- QUALIFICATION: Arthashastra monopolies are prescriptions, not an audited economy.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Economy debate.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 19 - Coinage

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which caution applies to Mauryan punch-marked coins?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Every symbol is a dated portrait of Ashoka	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	All were gold dinaras	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Symbols may have political or religious meaning, but ruler attribution is often speculative	Correct	Coin use and monetisation remained uneven.
D	They ended payments in kind	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Symbols may have political or religious meaning, but ruler attribution is often speculative
- EXPLANATION: The motifs came from a broad early-historic cultural pool.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Silver punch-marked coins and symbol studies
- QUALIFICATION: Coin use and monetisation remained uneven.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Coinage.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 20 - Urban archaeology

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which archaeological pair most directly supports a large wooden fortified Pataliputra?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Maski and Brahmagiri	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Sanchi and Bharhut	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Dhuli and Jaugada	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Kumrahar and Bulandibagh	Correct	The hall's exact function and stratigraphy remain debated.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Kumrahar and Bulandibagh
- EXPLANATION: Kumrahar has a pillared hall; Bulandibagh has wooden palisade remains.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Excavations at ancient Patna
- QUALIFICATION: The hall's exact function and stratigraphy remain debated.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Urban archaeology.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 21 - Megasthenes society

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Megasthenes' seven social groups are best understood as:

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	A Greek classificatory construction mixing occupations and administrative ranks	Correct	Some notices still capture heredity/endogamy tendencies.
B	The official seven varnas of Mauryan law	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	An Ashokan census table	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Seven Buddhist monastic grades	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - A Greek classificatory construction mixing occupations and administrative ranks
- EXPLANATION: They do not correspond to varna or jati.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Indica fragments and Thapar's analysis
- QUALIFICATION: Some notices still capture heredity/endogamy tendencies.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Megasthenes society.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 22 - SlaveryPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which evidence directly contradicts Megasthenes' claim that India had no slaves?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	The Seleucus treaty	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Ashoka's reference to dasas and bhatakas	Correct	Terms cover varied forms of dependence and do not quantify prevalence.
C	The Sarnath wheel	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	The Kalsi elephant alone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Ashoka's reference to dasas and bhatakas
- EXPLANATION: Rock edicts prescribe courteous conduct toward slaves and servants.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rock Edicts IX/XI
- QUALIFICATION: Terms cover varied forms of dependence and do not quantify prevalence.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK**Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Slavery.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE***Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 23 - Women

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What can the Queen's Edict of Karuvaki most securely demonstrate?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	General equality of all Mauryan women	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Female control of the entire army	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Elite female authority to make recorded pious gifts	Correct	An elite case cannot represent all women.
D	Abolition of patriarchal norms	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Elite female authority to make recorded pious gifts
- EXPLANATION: The inscription records groves, gardens and alms-house gifts.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Karuvaki's inscription on Allahabad-Kosam pillar
- QUALIFICATION: An elite case cannot represent all women.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Women.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 24 - Religious pluralityPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which fact most clearly disproves the claim that Ashoka established an exclusively Buddhist state religion?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	His pilgrimage to Lumbini	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	His use of Brahmi	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	His conquest of Kalinga	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	His Barabar cave donations to Ajivikas and calls to honour all sects	Correct	Plural patronage still operated under paternal monarchy.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - His Barabar cave donations to Ajivikas and calls to honour all sects
- EXPLANATION: Patronage and public policy were plural despite personal Buddhism.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Barabar inscriptions; Rock Edict XII
- QUALIFICATION: Plural patronage still operated under paternal monarchy.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Religious plurality.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 25 - Kalinga chronology

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Major Rock Edict XIII dates the Kalinga conquest to:

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	After eight completed years from Ashoka's consecration	Correct	The absolute BCE year depends on the reign chronology used.
B	Before Chandragupta's accession	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	After Ashoka's death	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	The final year of Bindusara	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - After eight completed years from Ashoka's consecration
- EXPLANATION: The war occurred in the ninth regnal year after abhisheka.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict XIII
- QUALIFICATION: The absolute BCE year depends on the reign chronology used.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Kalinga chronology.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 26 - Kalinga casualties

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

How should the Kalinga casualty numbers be used?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	As modern census-certified totals	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	As Ashoka's inscriptional claims, not independently audited statistics	Correct	Their rhetorical and commemorative context matters.
C	As figures from Megasthenes' Indica	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	As proof that Kalinga was uninhabited afterward	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - As Ashoka's inscriptional claims, not independently audited statistics
- EXPLANATION: The figures are powerful direct royal testimony but not corroborated counts.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict XIII
- QUALIFICATION: Their rhetorical and commemorative context matters.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Kalinga casualties.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 27 - Separate edictsPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Why are Dhauli and Jaugada especially important?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	They contain the Sarnath lion capital	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	They are the only Kharoshthi sites	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	They preserve Separate Kalinga Edicts on post-conquest administration and confidence-building	Correct	Policy orders do not prove complete implementation.
D	They record Chandragupta's Seleucus treaty	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - They preserve Separate Kalinga Edicts on post-conquest administration and confidence-building
- EXPLANATION: Their regional text replaces parts of the standard major-edict sequence.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Separate Rock Edicts I-II
- QUALIFICATION: Policy orders do not prove complete implementation.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Separate edicts.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 28 - Dhamma

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which formulation best defines Ashoka's public dhamma?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	The complete Buddhist monastic Vinaya	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	A modern secular constitution	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	A programme of compulsory conversion	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	An imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, focused on conduct, non-injury, welfare and concord	Correct	Dhamma remained paternal and tied to merit/heaven.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - An imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, focused on conduct, non-injury, welfare and concord
- EXPLANATION: The edicts address everyday relations and multiple sects.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rock Edicts VII, IX, XI, XII and pillar edicts
- QUALIFICATION: Dhamma remained paternal and tied to merit/heaven.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Dhamma.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 29 - Religious concord

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Major Rock Edict XII goes beyond passive tolerance by urging:

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Restraint, listening and growth in the essentials of all sects	Correct	Royal exhortation does not prove conflict ended.
B	Destruction of every non-Buddhist shrine	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Election of monks as governors	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	End of royal patronage	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Restraint, listening and growth in the essentials of all sects
- EXPLANATION: The edict seeks dialogue and mutual understanding.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict XII
- QUALIFICATION: Royal exhortation does not prove conflict ended.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Religious concord.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 30 - Personal Buddhism

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which inscription most directly describes Ashoka as a lay follower who became more zealous gradually?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Major Rock Edict XIII alone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Minor Rock Edict I	Correct	The wording varies across versions.
C	The Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	The Sohgaure plaque	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Minor Rock Edict I
- EXPLANATION: Minor Rock Edict I gives a staged account of lay affiliation and effort.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Minor Rock Edict I
- QUALIFICATION: The wording varies across versions.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Personal Buddhism.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 31 - Bhabru

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What is distinctive about the Bhabru/Bairat inscription?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	It lists all Mauryan tax rates	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	It records the Seleucid marriage	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Ashoka recommends specific Buddhist texts to monks, nuns and lay followers	Correct	It should not be treated as the content of all public dhamma edicts.
D	It is written only in Greek	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Ashoka recommends specific Buddhist texts to monks, nuns and lay followers
- EXPLANATION: It is direct evidence of personal Buddhist textual preference.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Bhabru Minor Rock Edict
- QUALIFICATION: It should not be treated as the content of all public dhamma edicts.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Bhabru.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 32 - Dhamma machinery

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Who were the principal special officers for Ashoka's dhamma programme?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Only Greek ambassadors	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Shunga feudatories	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Harappan merchants	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Dhamma-mahamattas	Correct	Their effectiveness cannot be measured from the edict alone.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Dhamma-mahamattas
- EXPLANATION: They worked across social groups, sects and frontier communities.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict V
- QUALIFICATION: Their effectiveness cannot be measured from the edict alone.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Dhamma machinery.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 33 - Audience

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Who formed the largest practical audience for many edicts?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Subjects hearing the message through officials and oral recitation	Correct	Reception varied by language, authority and local conditions.
B	Only literate royal scribes reading privately	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Only Hellenistic kings	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Only Buddhist monks at Pataliputra	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Subjects hearing the message through officials and oral recitation
- EXPLANATION: Low literacy and difficult placements made intermediaries essential.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Separate edicts; Rock Edict III; oral-reading instructions
- QUALIFICATION: Reception varied by language, authority and local conditions.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Audience.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 34 - Scripts

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which script-language pairing is correct?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Girnar - Greek only	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Shahbazgarhi - Kharoshthi and north-western Prakrit	Correct	Script choice does not by itself identify ethnicity.
C	Kandahar - Brahmi only	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Mansehra - Tamil-Brahmi only	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Shahbazgarhi - Kharoshthi and north-western Prakrit
- EXPLANATION: Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra use Kharoshthi.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Ashokan inscription corpus
- QUALIFICATION: Script choice does not by itself identify ethnicity.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Scripts.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 35 - Major rock sites

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which pair consists of two Kalinga major/separate-edict sites in Odisha?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Kalsi and Girnar	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Maski and Brahmagiri	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Dhuli and Jaugada	Correct	Exact administrative-centre identifications remain debated.
D	Mansehra and Shahbazgarhi	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Dhuli and Jaugada
- EXPLANATION: Dhuli and Jaugada carry regionally adapted Kalinga texts.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Ashokan site list
- QUALIFICATION: Exact administrative-centre identifications remain debated.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Major rock sites.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 36 - Pillars

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which site preserves an Ashokan pillar inscription commemorating the Buddha's birthplace and a tax concession?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Kanaganahalli	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Sohgaura	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Sopara	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Rummindei (Lumbini)	Correct	It is a local commemoration, not a general tax code.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Rummindei (Lumbini)
- EXPLANATION: The Rummindei inscription records the royal visit and fiscal privilege.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rummindei pillar
- QUALIFICATION: It is a local commemoration, not a general tax code.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Pillars.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 37 - Southern neighbours

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which group is presented in the edicts as southern neighbours rather than securely annexed provinces?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Cholas, Pandyas, Keralaputras and Satiyaputras	Correct	Dhamma outreach is not territorial sovereignty.
B	Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Kandahar, Mansehra, Kalsi and Girnar	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Pataliputra, Kaushambi, Vaishali and Rajgir	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Cholas, Pandyas, Keralaputras and Satiyaputras
- EXPLANATION: Rock Edicts II/XIII distinguish these polities from the imperial domain.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edicts II and XIII
- QUALIFICATION: Dhamma outreach is not territorial sovereignty.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Southern neighbours.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 38 - Foreign horizon

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What do the Hellenistic kings named in Rock Edict XIII prove most securely?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Mauryan annexation of Egypt and Macedonia	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Ashoka's awareness of and claimed moral outreach to a wider geopolitical world	Correct	The claim does not verify reception or conversion abroad.
C	Conversion certificates from all five courts	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	A Greek army stationed at Sanchi	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Ashoka's awareness of and claimed moral outreach to a wider geopolitical world
- EXPLANATION: The names frame dhamma-vijaya beyond the subcontinent.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict XIII
- QUALIFICATION: The claim does not verify reception or conversion abroad.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Foreign horizon.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 39 - Sarnath capital

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which feature belongs to the Sarnath Lion Capital?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	A fluted shaft on a square Persian base	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	A seated portrait labelled Ranyo Ashoka	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Four back-to-back lions above an animal-and-wheel abacus	Correct	The modern emblem is a later national adoption.
D	A cave facade dedicated to Ajivikas	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Four back-to-back lions above an animal-and-wheel abacus
- EXPLANATION: The capital is a Mauryan sculptural and symbolic masterpiece.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: ASI Sarnath; archaeological corpus
- QUALIFICATION: The modern emblem is a later national adoption.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Sarnath capital.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 40 - Sanchi layers

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about Sanchi Stupa 1 is correct?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Its toranas were carved by Chandragupta	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	It was entirely Gupta	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	It began as an Ajivika cave	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Its brick core is Ashokan, while major stone casing, railings and gateways are later	Correct	Visible fabric combines several dynasties.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Its brick core is Ashokan, while major stone casing, railings and gateways are later
- EXPLANATION: The floor relationship with the Ashokan pillar supports the Mauryan core.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Sanchi archaeology; UNESCO/ASI
- QUALIFICATION: Visible fabric combines several dynasties.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Sanchi layers.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 41 - Barabar

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Ashokan cave dedications at Barabar were made primarily to:

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Ajivikas	Correct	Lomash Rishi lacks the same dedication but is contextually close.
B	Roman traders	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Shaiva mathas	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Greek soldiers	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Ajivikas
- EXPLANATION: The inscriptions name the Ajivika sect.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Barabar cave inscriptions
- QUALIFICATION: Lomash Rishi lacks the same dedication but is contextually close.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Barabar.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 42 - Kumrahar

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What is the safest description of the Kumrahar eighty-pillared remains?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	A securely identified throne room named in an Ashokan edict	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	A major Mauryan-associated hall whose exact function remains debated	Correct	Tourism labels can be more definite than archaeology.
C	A Harappan granary	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	A Gupta cave temple	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - A major Mauryan-associated hall whose exact function remains debated
- EXPLANATION: The pillars and structural traces establish scale, not an uncontested function.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Kumrahar excavation record
- QUALIFICATION: Tourism labels can be more definite than archaeology.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Kumrahar.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 43 - Polish

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Why is 'Mauryan polish' an unsafe sole dating criterion?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Mauryan craftsmen never polished stone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Only wooden objects were polished	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Highly polished stone surfaces continued after the Mauryan period	Correct	Polish remains useful when combined with inscription, style and context.
D	Every Ashokan pillar is unpolished	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Highly polished stone surfaces continued after the Mauryan period
- EXPLANATION: Objects such as Didarganj and other figures have disputed dates.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Upinder Singh's art discussion
- QUALIFICATION: Polish remains useful when combined with inscription, style and context.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Polish.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 44 - Art interactionPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which formulation best captures Persian/Hellenistic influence on Mauryan art?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Exact copying of Persepolis	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Complete isolation from western Asia	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	A purely Greek workforce proven by style	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Selective borrowing and transformation within distinct Indian forms and meanings	Correct	Artist ethnicity cannot be inferred from motif alone.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Selective borrowing and transformation within distinct Indian forms and meanings
- EXPLANATION: Shared motifs coexist with major formal and semantic differences.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Pillar comparisons; script/art contact
- QUALIFICATION: Artist ethnicity cannot be inferred from motif alone.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK**Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Art interaction.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE***Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 45 - Centralisation

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which is the most defensible model of the Mauryan state?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	A strong but differentiated empire with regionally and functionally varied control	Correct	The balance may differ by reign and zone.
B	A modern unitary nation-state	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	A purely symbolic realm without taxation or officers	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Identical administration in every village	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - A strong but differentiated empire with regionally and functionally varied control
- EXPLANATION: Provinces and officers show capacity; communication and regional archaeology show variation.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Edicts, archaeology, Thapar/Fussman/Sugandhi debate
- QUALIFICATION: The balance may differ by reign and zone.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Centralisation.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 46 - Communication

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Why do inspection tours simultaneously indicate capacity and limitation?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	They prove instant telecommunication	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	They show active supervision but also dependence on slow movement and intermediaries	Correct	Frequency does not reveal complete route coverage.
C	They eliminated provincial governors	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	They were only religious pilgrimages	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - They show active supervision but also dependence on slow movement and intermediaries
- EXPLANATION: Five- and three-year tours connected centre and field.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Rock Edict III and Separate Rock Edict I
- QUALIFICATION: Frequency does not reveal complete route coverage.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Communication.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 47 - Memory

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

What do the Kanaganahalli reliefs most directly reveal?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Ashoka's verified physical appearance	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	The text of the Seleucus treaty	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	The post-Mauryan Buddhist iconic memory of Ashoka	Correct	They were carved centuries after Ashoka.
D	The original Sarnath wheel	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - The post-Mauryan Buddhist iconic memory of Ashoka
- EXPLANATION: Labelled reliefs show how later Buddhist communities represented him.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Kanaganahalli excavations and labels
- QUALIFICATION: They were carved centuries after Ashoka.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Memory.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Hard MCQ 48 - Method

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which answer sentence best follows evidence discipline?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Ashoka became completely nonviolent and abolished the state	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	The Arthashastra proves every Mauryan monopoly operated	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Megasthenes accurately described all India	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Rock Edict XIII proclaims remorse and dhamma-vijaya, but its warning to forest peoples shows retained coercive authority	Correct	No single source exhausts the empire.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Rock Edict XIII proclaims remorse and dhamma-vijaya, but its warning to forest peoples shows retained coercive authority
- EXPLANATION: The sentence names evidence, significance and qualification.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Major Rock Edict XIII
- QUALIFICATION: No single source exhausts the empire.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Method.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 49 - Arthashastra trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which correction is necessary when using the Arthashastra?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Call it a theoretical/redacted text and corroborate Mauryan claims	Correct	Some concepts may preserve earlier traditions.
B	Treat every prescription as an executed imperial order	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Date it only from Chandragupta's court without debate	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Use it instead of inscriptions	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Call it a theoretical/redacted text and corroborate Mauryan claims
- EXPLANATION: The final text describes a potential monarchy, not a transparent Mauryan manual.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Arthashastra dating debate
- QUALIFICATION: Some concepts may preserve earlier traditions.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK**Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Arthashastra trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE***Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 50 - Map trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

What is wrong with equating the edict map with uniform direct administration?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Edicts are not ancient	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Communication claims and actual control can vary by region	Correct	Absence and presence both require preservation caution.
C	All edicts were moved to Delhi	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Brahmi was unreadable in Ashoka's time	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - Communication claims and actual control can vary by region
- EXPLANATION: Find-spots must be combined with local archaeology and political context.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Regional edict distribution
- QUALIFICATION: Absence and presence both require preservation caution.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Map trap.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 51 - Founder trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Who founded the Mauryan dynasty?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Ashoka	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Bindusara	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Chandragupta Maurya	Correct	Exact date and early sequence vary.
D	Pushyamitra Shunga	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Chandragupta Maurya
- EXPLANATION: Chandragupta overthrew the Nandas and created Mauryan power.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Dynastic traditions and classical notices
- QUALIFICATION: Exact date and early sequence vary.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Founder trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE**

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 52 - Dhamma trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which correction best addresses 'dhamma was the Mauryan state religion'?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Ashoka had no relation to Buddhism	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Dhamma meant only tax collection	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Every subject was compelled to become a monk	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Ashoka was personally Buddhist, but public dhamma was a broader plural social ethic	Correct	Dhamma retained Buddhist roots and paternal authority.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Ashoka was personally Buddhist, but public dhamma was a broader plural social ethic
- EXPLANATION: Minor edicts and Rock Edict XII must be read together.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: MRE I/Bhabru; RE XII; Barabar gifts
- QUALIFICATION: Dhamma retained Buddhist roots and paternal authority.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK**Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Dhamma trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE***Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 53 - Pacifism trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which evidence blocks the claim that Ashoka abolished all coercion?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Forest warning and continued death penalty	Correct	Ashoka's anti-war reflection remains historically significant.
B	The Sarnath abacus alone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	The Mahavamsa mission list alone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	The Parkham yaksha	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - Forest warning and continued death penalty
- EXPLANATION: Rock Edict XIII and Pillar Edict IV retain punishment.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: RE XIII; PE IV
- QUALIFICATION: Ashoka's anti-war reflection remains historically significant.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK**Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Pacifism trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE***Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 54 - Sanchi trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which element of the Great Stupa is Mauryan?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	The carved toranas in their present form	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	The original brick core	Correct	Exact reconstructions of the first phase are limited.
C	All visible stone railings	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	The Gupta Buddha images	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - The original brick core
- EXPLANATION: The monumental site accumulated layers across dynasties.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Sanchi archaeology and ASI/UNESCO
- QUALIFICATION: Exact reconstructions of the first phase are limited.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional context or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Sanchi trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE**

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 55 - Cave trap

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Barabar cave inscriptions are crucial because they show:

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	An exclusive Buddhist state	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	A Greek naval base	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Ashokan patronage of Ajivikas and early rock-cut architecture	Correct	Not every nearby cave has the same inscription.
D	A Gupta land grant	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Ashokan patronage of Ajivikas and early rock-cut architecture
- EXPLANATION: The dedication and technology are both historically significant.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Barabar inscriptions
- QUALIFICATION: Not every nearby cave has the same inscription.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Cave trap.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 56 - Polish trap

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

A polished stone figure without stratified context should be dated by:

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Polish alone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	Modern popularity	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Its museum label alone	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Combining inscription, style, material technology and context	Correct	Different indicators may conflict.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - Combining inscription, style, material technology and context
- EXPLANATION: Mauryan-style polish continued later.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Didarganj/Lohanipur/Parkham debates
- QUALIFICATION: Different indicators may conflict.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Polish trap.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 57 - Megasthenes trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Which Megasthenes statement is demonstrably unsafe?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	India had no slaves	Correct	Forms of dependence varied.
B	Pataliputra used much wood	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	He visited a Mauryan court	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	India had elephants	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: A - India had no slaves
- EXPLANATION: Ashokan and Indian textual evidence names slaves/servants.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: RE IX/XI and other texts
- QUALIFICATION: Forms of dependence varied.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: A.
2. Coverage area: Megasthenes trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE**

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 58 - Officer trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta should be remembered as:

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	One identical village office	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	District-level officers in the 2025 official key, with distinct functions	Correct	Ancient levels do not map perfectly onto modern districts.
C	Three Buddhist sects	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	Foreign kings	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: B - District-level officers in the 2025 official key, with distinct functions
- EXPLANATION: The exam fact and functional caveat must coexist.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: UPSC 2025 Q19; RE III
- QUALIFICATION: Ancient levels do not map perfectly onto modern districts.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK

Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Correct option: B.
2. Coverage area: Officer trap.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Choose by a familiar keyword.

CORRECT: Identify the evidence class and historical level first.

WRONG: Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.

CORRECT: Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.

MAINS ANGLE

Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 59 - Kalinga trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

What happened territorially after Ashoka's remorse?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	Kalinga was immediately restored as an independent kingdom	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	The Mauryan capital moved to Dhauri	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	Kalinga remained incorporated while policy language and governance changed	Correct	Degree of pacification is uncertain.
D	The army was transferred to Seleucus	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: C - Kalinga remained incorporated while policy language and governance changed
- EXPLANATION: Separate edicts address post-conquest administration.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: RE XIII; Separate Kalinga Edicts
- QUALIFICATION: Degree of pacification is uncertain.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK**Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Correct option: C.
2. Coverage area: Kalinga trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE***Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ 60 - Mission trapPrelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

How should the Mahinda-Sanghamitta mission be presented?

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
A	As a verbatim Ashokan edict	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
B	As a Hellenistic treaty clause	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
C	As an event denied by all Buddhist sources	Distractor	Reject by source/chronology/category
D	As a later Sri Lankan chronicle tradition with possible contextual corroboration	Correct	The full mission list cannot be independently verified.

STATIC THEORY

- KEY: D - As a later Sri Lankan chronicle tradition with possible contextual corroboration
- EXPLANATION: The tradition is historically important but not contemporary inscriptional proof.
- NAMED EVIDENCE: Mahavamsa/Dipavamsa; Sanchi relic context
- QUALIFICATION: The full mission list cannot be independently verified.
- ELIMINATION: Reject options that confuse source genre, chronology, inscriptional claim, regional contact or later memory with realised empire-wide practice.

MEMORY HOOK**Answer -> evidence -> eliminate -> qualify.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Correct option: D.
2. Coverage area: Mission trap.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Choose by a familiar keyword.**CORRECT:** Identify the evidence class and historical level first.**WRONG:** Ignore absolute words such as all, only or uniform.**CORRECT:** Test each absolute claim against regional and source variation.**MAINS ANGLE***Convert objective elimination into one precise evidence unit for Mains.***STUDY LINK**

Topic 14 consolidated practice.

HIGH

Original solved 10-marker 1 - Sources of Mauryan history

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Solved 10-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Edicts	Rock Edicts VI, XII, XIII; Pillar Edict IV	Direct royal voice on duty, concord, Kalinga and justice	Intent is clearer than implementation
Archaeology	Kumrahar, Bulandibagh, Sanchi and Barabar	Material institutions and technology	Function/identity may be debated
Megasthenes	Indica through Strabo/Arrian	Court and Pataliputra observations	Double filter and errors
Arthashastra	Redacted statecraft treatise	Political-economic ideas	Not a Mauryan manual

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Why must the Mauryan Empire be reconstructed through source criticism rather than by combining all available texts at face value? (150 words)

- THESIS: Mauryan reconstruction is unusually rich but methodologically difficult because inscriptions, archaeology, classical fragments, theoretical texts and later traditions answer different questions.

- MODEL ANSWER 1: Mauryan history cannot be written by merging unlike archives. Ashoka's edicts are contemporary and securely reveal his public voice: Rock Edict XIII records Kalinga remorse, Rock Edict XII sectarian concord and Pillar Edict IV judicial restraint. Yet they are royal proclamations and seldom describe routine administration.

- MODEL ANSWER 2: Archaeology at Bulandibagh and Kumrahar partly supports a wooden fortified Pataliputra and a large pillared hall, but the hall's exact function remains disputed. Megasthenes is valuable for the court and city, yet his lost Indica survives through later writers and contains errors such as denying slavery. The Arthashastra offers sophisticated statecraft prescriptions, but its composition/redaction and non-descriptive genre prevent treating it as Chandragupta's constitution. Buddhist, Jain and Puranic texts preserve memory but are later and sectarian.

- MODEL ANSWER 3: Therefore, claims should be accepted only at the level supported by genre, date and corroboration.

- Why this earns marks: The answer names four source classes, supplies precise examples, states what each proves, and ends with a method rather than a source list.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 10.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.
- CORRECT:** Answer the exact analytical demand.
- WRONG:** List evidence without inference.
- CORRECT:** Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.

MAINS ANGLE

Mauryan reconstruction is unusually rich but methodologically difficult because inscriptions, archaeology, classical fragments, theoretical texts and later traditions answer different questions.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH

Original solved 10-marker 2 - Chandragupta and imperial foundation

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Solved 10-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Foundation	Nanda-overthrow traditions	Control of Magadha and Pataliputra	Narrative details vary
North-west	Justin/Plutarch notices	Large conquest remembered	Army figures and 'India' are imprecise
Diplomacy	Seleucus settlement and 500 elephants	Stabilised frontier and exchanged military assets	Date/marriage clauses uncertain
West/south	Junagadh inscription; Mamulanar/Jain traditions	Saurashtra and possible trans-Vindhyan reach	Later/poetic evidence

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Assess Chandragupta Maurya's role in creating the Mauryan Empire. (150 words)
- THESIS: Chandragupta converted the inherited Magadhan-Nanda fiscal-military base and north-western political fluidity into a durable imperial framework through conquest and diplomacy.
- MODEL ANSWER 1: Chandragupta was the principal architect of Mauryan power, not merely Ashoka's predecessor. He overthrew the Nandas and secured Magadha's agrarian-revenue base, Pataliputra and inherited military resources. Graeco-Roman writers remember Sandrocottus as a conqueror of great scale, although their 600,000 figure and use of 'India' are not precise statistics.
- MODEL ANSWER 2: His conflict and treaty with Seleucus, conventionally placed around 305-301 BCE, demonstrate strategic diplomacy: the tradition records territorial concessions in the north-west and 500 elephants supplied to Seleucus, while the alleged marriage alliance remains uncertain. Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription attributes the beginning of the Sudarshana reservoir to Chandragupta's governor Pushyagupta, supporting western administration. Tamil and Jain traditions suggest southern links but are too late or poetic to map direct rule.
- MODEL ANSWER 3: Thus Chandragupta created the core, frontier settlement and governing scale that Bindusara preserved and Ashoka later articulated inscriptionally.
- Why this earns marks: It answers role rather than biography, uses four named evidence units, and qualifies every indirect tradition.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 10.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.**CORRECT:** Answer the exact analytical demand.**WRONG:** List evidence without inference.**CORRECT:** Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.**MAINS ANGLE**

Chandragupta converted the inherited Magadhan-Nanda fiscal-military base and north-western political fluidity into a durable imperial framework through conquest and diplomacy.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH**Original solved 10-marker 3 - Dhamma and Buddhism**Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Solved 10-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Personal Buddhism	Minor Rock Edict I; Bhabru; Rummindei	Lay adherence, Buddhist texts and pilgrimage	Special inscriptions
Public conduct	Rock Edicts IX and XI	Parents, elders, servants, generosity and non-killing	Maintains hierarchy
Concord	Rock Edicts VII and XII	Honour/listen to all sects	Not modern secularism
Plural patronage	Barabar caves for Ajivikas	State not exclusively Buddhist	Royal paternalism remains

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Ashoka's dhamma was not simply Buddhism. Explain. (150 words)

- THESIS: Ashoka's public dhamma was an imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, while his personal Buddhist adherence had a separate and explicit inscriptional record.

- MODEL ANSWER 1: Ashoka's Buddhism and dhamma overlap but are not identical. Minor Rock Edict I calls him a lay follower who gradually became more zealous; the Bhabru edict recommends Buddhist texts, and Rummindei records his Lumbini pilgrimage. These establish personal faith.

- MODEL ANSWER 2: The major public edicts, however, define dhamma through social conduct: respect for parents and elders, courtesy to slaves and servants, generosity to Brahmanas and shramanas, self-control and reduced injury to living beings. Rock Edict XII asks sects to restrain self-praise, listen to others and promote concord. Such an ethic addresses a plural empire and omits central Buddhist teachings such as the Four Noble Truths and nirvana. Ashoka also donated Barabar caves to Ajivikas.

- MODEL ANSWER 3: Dhamma was therefore a Buddhist-inflected ethical-political programme for imperial society, not compulsory conversion or a Buddhist state religion.

- Why this earns marks: The answer distinguishes faith, doctrine, public policy and patronage with four named inscriptions and a clear verdict.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 10.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.**CORRECT:** Answer the exact analytical demand.**WRONG:** List evidence without inference.**CORRECT:** Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.**MAINS ANGLE**

Ashoka's public dhamma was an imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, while his personal Buddhist adherence had a separate and explicit inscriptional record.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH**Original solved 15-marker 1 - Mauryan administration**Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Solved 15-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Centre	King, parishad and Rock Edict VI reporters	Command and information	Royal ideal
Province	Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali, Suvarnagiri; kumaras	Regional supervision	Reconstructed scheme
District	Pradeshika, rajuka, yukta	Tours, justice and field administration	Ranks/functions overlap
Special cadres	Mahamattas, pativedakas, pulisani	Portfolio and reporting differentiation	Titles do not give staff depth
Municipal/military	Megasthenes' six committees	Possible Pataliputra arrangements	Fragmentary and suspiciously symmetrical

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Examine the structure and working of Mauryan administration with reference to the strengths and limits of the evidence. (250 words)
- THESIS: The Mauryan state had a substantial multi-tiered hierarchy and information network, but its exact organisation and reach must be reconstructed mainly from Ashokan inscriptions and regionally bounded corroboration.
- MODEL ANSWER 1: Mauryan administration was organised around the king, consultative bodies, provincial centres and mobile field officers. Rock Edict VI presents Ashoka as continuously accessible to pativedakas and requires disputes in the parishad to reach him immediately. This indicates a strong ideal of personal command, while also revealing dependence on reporters.
- MODEL ANSWER 2: The empire appears to have had major provincial centres at Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri, often under kumaras or aryaputras. The later Junagadh inscription names Pushyagupta as Chandragupta's governor in Saurashtra. At district level, Rock Edict III groups pradeshikas, rajukas and yuktas for five-year tours; the 2025 official UPSC key identifies them as district officers. Rajukas also received judicial and welfare duties in Pillar Edict IV.
- MODEL ANSWER 3: Specialised mahamattas included frontier, women's-affairs and dhamma cadres. Separate Rock Edict I ordered scrutiny of arbitrary imprisonment in Kalinga, showing both corrective capacity and official misconduct. Megasthenes' six municipal and military committees may reflect Pataliputra, but the lost Indica's fragmentary transmission and schematic symmetry require caution. Arthashastra offices such as samaharta and sannidhata are valuable theoretical comparators, not automatically attested Mauryan posts.
- MODEL ANSWER 4: Thus the state was administratively ambitious and layered, but uneven field reach, communication delays and source genre prevent describing it as a modern uniform bureaucracy.
- Why this earns marks: It covers centre, province, district, special officers, justice and city/military claims; every institutional claim carries a named source and limitation.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 15.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.
- CORRECT:** Answer the exact analytical demand.
- WRONG:** List evidence without inference.
- CORRECT:** Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.

MAINS ANGLE

The Mauryan state had a substantial multi-tiered hierarchy and information network, but its exact organisation and reach must be reconstructed mainly from Ashokan inscriptions and regionally bounded corroboration.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH

Original solved 15-marker 2 - Kalinga and post-war policy

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Solved 15-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Violence	Major Rock Edict XIII casualty/deportation claim	Royal recognition of conquest's social cost	Figures unverified
Moral turn	First-person remorse	Confessional political language	Also self-fashioning
Administration	Separate Kalinga Edicts I-II	Fairness, trust and paternalism	Implementation unknown
New conquest	Dhamma-vijaya	Moral influence preferred to fresh annexation	Not foreign sovereignty
Coercive remainder	Forest warning; Pillar Edict IV	Punishment and death penalty retained	Does not negate ethical innovation

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Analyse how the Kalinga war altered Ashoka's conception and practice of kingship. (250 words)
- THESIS: Kalinga did not end Mauryan coercion; it transformed Ashoka's public kingship by making suffering, restraint, welfare and dhamma-vijaya central to imperial legitimacy.
- MODEL ANSWER 1: Major Rock Edict XIII presents Kalinga as a decisive reflection on kingship. Ashoka records 150,000 deported, 100,000 killed and many more dead; these are royal inscriptional claims rather than audited totals. More important is his expansion of suffering beyond combatants to relatives, householders, Brahmanas, shramanas, slaves and servants. Victory is therefore judged by its dispersed human cost.
- MODEL ANSWER 2: The policy response had three dimensions. First, Ashoka preferred dhamma-vijaya—moral influence and restraint—over fresh territorial conquest and urged successors to avoid harsh warfare. Second, the Separate Kalinga Edicts addressed officials at Tosali and Samapa, demanded confidence-building and fair justice, and expressed the paternal formula that all people were his children. Third, the communication apparatus expanded through tours, oral readings and dhamma-mahamattas.
- MODEL ANSWER 3: Yet Kalinga did not produce absolute pacifism. The territory remained annexed; Rock Edict XIII warned forest peoples that the repentant king retained power to punish, and Pillar Edict IV presupposed capital punishment. Nor can the war be reduced to a sudden conversion, because Minor Rock Edict I indicates gradual Buddhist commitment.
- MODEL ANSWER 4: Kalinga thus transformed the language, ethical burden and declared priorities of rule while preserving the coercive foundations of empire.
- Why this earns marks: It analyses change in ideas, administration and coercion, uses three edict groups, and avoids both cynical strategy-only and total-pacifism readings.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 15.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.**CORRECT:** Answer the exact analytical demand.**WRONG:** List evidence without inference.**CORRECT:** Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.**MAINS ANGLE**

Kalinga did not end Mauryan coercion; it transformed Ashoka's public kingship by making suffering, restraint, welfare and dhamma-vijaya central to imperial legitimacy.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH**Original solved 15-marker 3 - Art as imperial communication**Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Solved 15-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Pillars	Sarnath, Sanchi, Vaishali and edict pillars	Royal presence and dhamma text	Not all pillars inscribed
Stupas	Sanchi brick core; Nigali Sagar	Buddhist commemoration and patronage	Later additions distinct
Caves	Barabar Ajivika donations	Rock technology and plural patronage	Not all Buddhist
Capital	Kumrahar hall and Bulandibagh palisade	Court/urban capacity	Function/date debated
Popular art	Terracottas, ring stones and Parkham yaksha	Urban belief and corporate donors	Dating/context uneven

STATIC THEORY

- **DEMAND:** Discuss Mauryan art and architecture as instruments of political communication as well as products of religious and craft traditions. (250 words)
- **THESIS:** Mauryan monumental art made imperial power visible, but its forms also drew on religious symbolism, artisan skill, transregional contact and non-royal patronage.
- **MODEL ANSWER 1:** Mauryan art communicated both imperial power and a wider religious-social world. Ashokan pillars combined long polished shafts, lotus-abacus-animal capitals and inscriptions. At Sarnath, four lions and wheels carried overlapping royal and Buddhist meanings; by placing dhamma proclamations on monumental stone, Ashoka converted artistic form into a durable political voice.
- **MODEL ANSWER 2:** Buddhist patronage is visible in Sanchi's Ashokan brick stupa core and the Nigali Sagar record of enlarging Kanakamuni's stupa. However, Sanchi's stone casing and toranas are later and must not be credited to Ashoka. Barabar cave inscriptions dedicate highly polished rock-cut spaces to Ajivikas, demonstrating plural patronage and the translation of wooden architectural forms into rock. Kumrahar's pillared hall and Bulandibagh's timber fortification suggest the scale of Pataliputra, though the hall's function remains debated.
- **MODEL ANSWER 3:** Court art did not exhaust the period. Parkham's inscribed Manibhadra yaksha, terracottas and ring stones reveal corporate and popular patronage. Persian/Hellenistic contacts influenced motifs and techniques, but smooth unbased shafts, independent animal capitals and ethical inscriptions created distinct forms.
- **MODEL ANSWER 4:** Mauryan art was therefore an imperial communication system embedded in religious plurality, workshop networks and early-historic urban culture.
- **Why this earns marks:** It covers pillars, stupas, caves, capital and popular art, dates layers, names inscriptions/sites, and balances influence with transformation.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 15.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.

CORRECT: Answer the exact analytical demand.

WRONG: List evidence without inference.

CORRECT: Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.

MAINS ANGLE

Mauryan monumental art made imperial power visible, but its forms also drew on religious symbolism, artisan skill, transregional contact and non-royal patronage.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH

Original solved 20-marker 1 - Centralised or differentiated empire

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Solved 20-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Central capacity	King, parishad, provinces, mahamattas and district officers	Hierarchy and delegation	Archive concentrated under Ashoka
Information/coercion	RE VI reporters; inspections; army and forest warning	Command, surveillance and deterrence	Latency and compliance problems
Regional adaptation	Greek/Aramaic versions and Kharoshthi north-west	Local official initiative	Not proof of autonomy in every sphere
Archaeological variation	Northern NBPW/art package versus southern Deccan	Uneven material integration	Excavation remains incomplete
Political model	Thapar, Fussman and Sugandhi	Metropolitan/core/periphery and communication limits	Models are interpretive

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Was the Mauryan Empire a highly centralised state? Critically evaluate with inscriptional and archaeological evidence. (350 words)

- THESIS: The Mauryan Empire possessed strong central institutions and strategic control, but its governance was differentiated by function, region, communication distance and inherited local structures.

- MODEL ANSWER 1: The Mauryan Empire was centralised in aspiration and in selected strategic functions, but not a uniformly administered territorial machine. A centralised reading rests on unprecedented scale, Pataliputra, royal princes at provincial centres, numerous mahamattas, district officers, fiscal extraction and a large army. Rock Edict VI orders patedakas to report affairs to Ashoka at any time; Rock Edict III sends pradeshikas, rajukas and yuktas on quinquennial tours. Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri linked major corridors to the court, while Separate Rock Edict I shows provincial inspection and judicial correction.

- MODEL ANSWER 2: Yet the same evidence discloses limits. Five-year tours and repeated orders were necessary because information moved slowly and officials could imprison or torture arbitrarily. Megasthenes' municipal and military committees may illuminate Pataliputra, but his lost work is filtered and cannot be generalised to all India. The Arthashastra's all-controlling state is a theoretical and redacted model, not a Mauryan administrative manual.

- MODEL ANSWER 3: Regional evidence strengthens the differentiated interpretation. Greek and Aramaic inscriptions in the north-west are adaptations rather than literal translations, implying local linguistic competence and discretion. Major rock edicts cluster toward borders, pillar edicts in north India and minor edicts strongly in the Andhra-Karnataka zone. Namita Sugandhi notes that southern regions do not reproduce the northern NBPW, coin and court-art package; an edict therefore marks contact and a claim to authority more securely than uniform direct rule.

- MODEL ANSWER 4: Historiographically, Thapar moved from a highly centralised formulation to a metropolitan-core-periphery model, while Fussman emphasised communication limits. These corrections should not erase capacity: governors, waterworks such as Sudarshana, judicial edicts, multilingual communication and deterrence were real.

- MODEL ANSWER 5: The best verdict is functionally graded: appointments, imperial ideology and strategic routes were relatively centralised; taxation, local justice, everyday production and frontier control depended more heavily on provincial officers, local intermediaries and negotiated variation.

- Why this earns marks: It defines centralisation by function, uses more than eight named evidence units, engages three interpretations, and reaches a graded rather than binary verdict.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 20.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.**CORRECT:** Answer the exact analytical demand.**WRONG:** List evidence without inference.**CORRECT:** Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.**MAINS ANGLE**

The Mauryan Empire possessed strong central institutions and strategic control, but its governance was differentiated by function, region, communication distance and inherited local structures.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH**Original solved 20-marker 2 - Power and piety under Ashoka**Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Solved 20-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Piety	MRE I, Bhabru, Rummindei and Nigali Sagar	Personal Buddhism and pilgrimage/patronage	Not equal to public policy
Public ethic	RE IX, XI and XII	Social duty and concord	Paternal, not egalitarian
Power	RE VI reporting; mahamattas; tours	Administrative mobilisation	Implementation variable
Kalinga	RE XIII and Separate Kalinga Edicts	Remorse plus post-conquest reform	Kalinga retained
Coercion	Forest warning; PE IV death penalty	Deterrence and punishment	Does not nullify ethical change

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Ashoka's kingship combined power and piety rather than replacing one with the other. Discuss. (350 words)
- THESIS: Ashoka moralised imperial power through dhamma, welfare and restraint, but his programme remained authoritative, administrative and coercively backed.
- MODEL ANSWER 1: Ashoka did not exchange empire for renunciation; he attempted to redefine how imperial power should be justified and exercised. His personal piety is explicit: Minor Rock Edict I presents gradual commitment as a Buddhist lay follower, the Bhabru edict recommends Buddhist texts, Rummindei records a Lumbini pilgrimage and Nigali Sagar the enlargement of a stupa. Nevertheless, the public dhamma of the major edicts was broader than Buddhism.
- MODEL ANSWER 2: Rock Edicts IX and XI translate morality into household and social duties—respect for parents and elders, courtesy to slaves and servants, generosity to Brahmanas and shramanas, and reduced injury. Rock Edict XII seeks restraint, listening and concord among sects. These ethical claims served a plural empire and created a new public language of rulership.
- MODEL ANSWER 3: The programme was also an exercise of power. Dhamma-mahamattas entered multiple social domains; pradeshikas, rajukas and yuktas toured districts; Rock Edict VI demanded reports at all times; inscriptions and oral readings carried the king's voice across routes and frontiers. Welfare measures—trees, wells, medicine and prisoner release claims—made paternal care part of legitimacy.
- MODEL ANSWER 4: Kalinga reveals the fusion most clearly. Rock Edict XIII condemns the dispersed suffering of conquest and elevates dhamma-vijaya, while the Separate Kalinga Edicts order fairer administration and confidence-building. Yet Kalinga remained annexed. The same Rock Edict XIII warns forest peoples of punitive power, and Pillar Edict IV retains capital punishment with a three-day respite.
- MODEL ANSWER 5: Ashoka's piety therefore constrained, redirected and legitimised power; it did not dissolve hierarchy, administration or coercion. His historical originality lies precisely in making moral self-scrutiny an imperial proclamation while retaining the machinery capable of enforcing rule.
- Why this earns marks: It integrates personal faith, public ethics, administration, welfare, Kalinga and coercion; named inscriptions support every claim and the conclusion resolves the apparent contradiction.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 20.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.
- CORRECT:** Answer the exact analytical demand.
- WRONG:** List evidence without inference.
- CORRECT:** Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.

MAINS ANGLE

Ashoka moralised imperial power through dhamma, welfare and restraint, but his programme remained authoritative, administrative and coercively backed.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

HIGH

Original solved 20-marker 3 - Economy and state control

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Solved 20-mark original question using claim -> named evidence -> significance -> qualification.

KEY DATA

Claim / category	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Fiscal base	Bhaga/bali and Rummindei concession	Agrarian extraction and local modification	Rates varied
Infrastructure	Sudarshana reservoir via Junagadh inscription	Provincial water management	Retrospective evidence
Urban regulation	Megasthenes' Pataliputra committees	Weights, trade and market tax	City-specific/fragmentary
Material economy	Coins, crafts and towns at Taxila, Mathura, Bhita and Ujjayini	Growth and specialisation	State causation not automatic
Maximal prescription	Arthashastra departments/monopolies	Potential high-capacity model	Post-Mauryan/redacted and normative

STATIC THEORY

- DEMAND: Critically examine the extent of Mauryan state control over the economy. (350 words)

- THESIS: The Mauryan state could intervene powerfully in land revenue, strategic resources, markets and infrastructure, but claims of a total command economy depend too heavily on the theoretical Arthashastra.

- MODEL ANSWER 1: Mauryan rule rested on a substantial agrarian and urban fiscal base, but the extent of direct state control must be graded. Land revenue was central: Indian norms commonly mention a one-sixth share, while the Rummindei pillar exempts Lumbini from bali and reduces bhaga to one-eighth. The concession proves both fiscal authority and local variation; it does not establish a uniform empire-wide rate.

- MODEL ANSWER 2: The later Junagadh inscription associates Chandragupta's governor Pushyagupta and Ashoka's official Tushaspha with the Sudarshana reservoir, showing provincial investment in strategic water infrastructure. Megasthenes' Pataliputra account describes committees concerned with weights, trade, public sale and market taxes. These fragments suggest urban regulation, but his city-specific, filtered account cannot be projected across the empire.

- MODEL ANSWER 3: Archaeology shows a broader economy with many actors. Taxila's shell workshop and urban drains, Mathura's metal and bead production, Bhita's nigama seal, Ujjayini's coins and ring wells, ports such as Sopara, and widespread punch-marked coins indicate crafts, corporate activity, routes and monetisation. The state may have secured corridors and collected dues, but merchants, artisans, cultivators and local elites remained indispensable.

- MODEL ANSWER 4: The strongest total-control claims come from the Arthashastra's departments, monopolies, settlement schemes and espionage. Current scholarship treats the extant work as a theoretical, redacted and largely post-Mauryan text; it describes a potential monarchy, not an audited Mauryan economy. Sharma's state-control model is therefore a hypothesis to test, not a fact to reproduce.

- MODEL ANSWER 5: The Mauryan economy was neither laissez-faire nor fully commanded. The state exercised selective high capacity in revenue, strategic works, markets and routes, while actual intervention varied by region and depended on non-state producers and intermediaries.

- Why this earns marks: It evaluates degree, uses inscriptional, classical, archaeological and textual evidence, names multiple sites, and explicitly resolves the prescription-versus-practice problem.

MEMORY HOOK

Demand -> thesis -> dimensions -> evidence -> balance -> verdict.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Marks: 20.
2. Every model answer ends with a marks rationale.
3. Evidence density is proportional to marks.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Narrate the chapter regardless of directive.

CORRECT: Answer the exact analytical demand.

WRONG: List evidence without inference.

CORRECT: Explain what each named unit proves and cannot prove.

MAINS ANGLE

The Mauryan state could intervene powerfully in land revenue, strategic resources, markets and infrastructure, but claims of a total command economy depend too heavily on the theoretical Arthashastra.

STUDY LINK

Topic 14 answer-worthiness architecture.

End of Register Notes - UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI